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On Western Ghats, South must break impasse

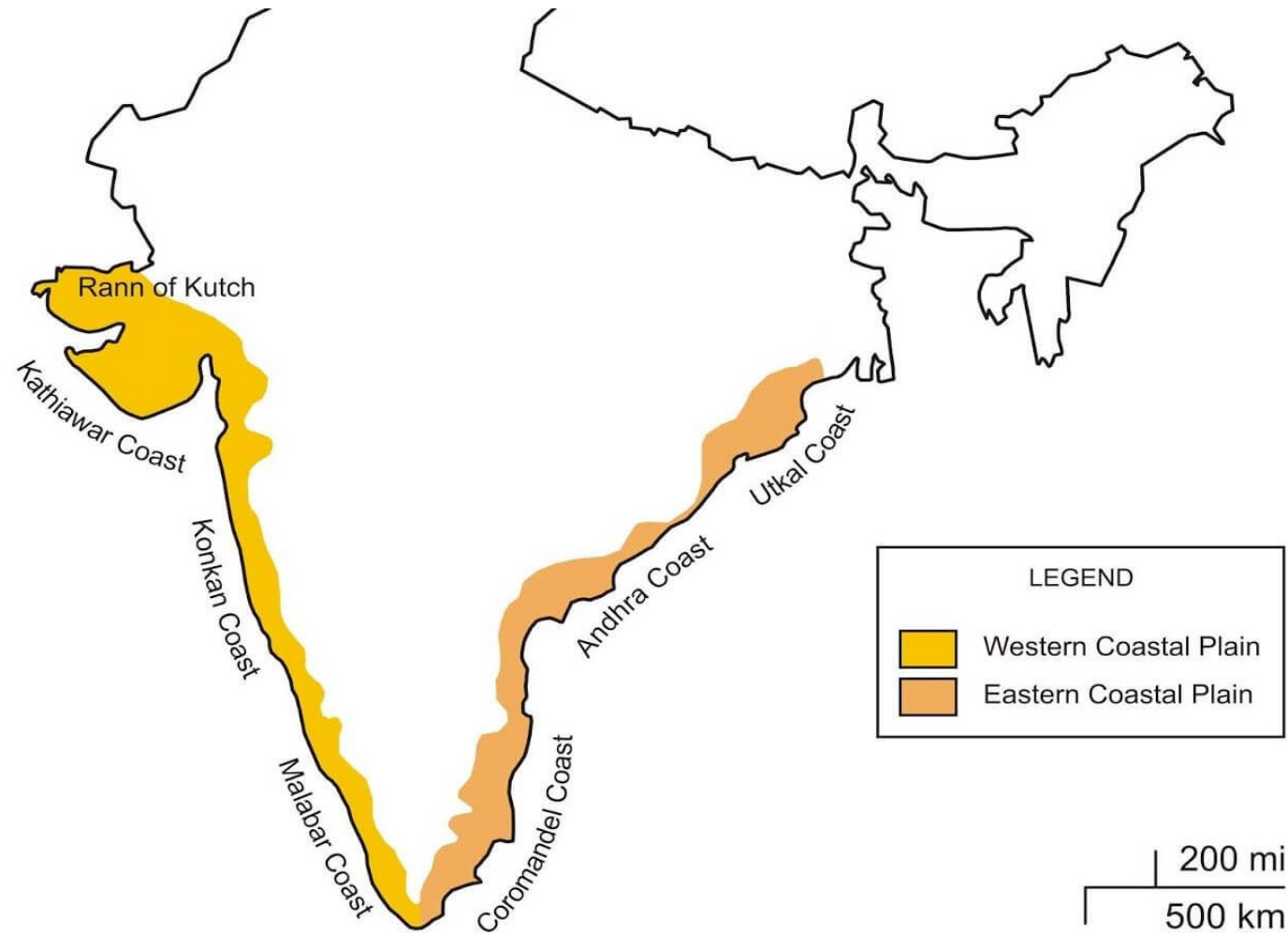
On Western Ghats, South must break impasse

THE IMPLEMENTATION of a series of measures to protect the Western Ghats, proposed by a committee headed by the eminent scientist K Kasturirangan, has been hanging fire for more than 12 years. State governments in the region — Maharashtra, Gujarat, Goa, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka — pushed back against the proposal to declare 60,000 sq km of the Western Ghats, roughly 37 per cent of the mountain chain, as an Ecologically Sensitive Area (ESA). They took exception to the Kasturirangan Committee's proposal to ban mining, polluting industries, thermal power plants and large constructions in the ESA. The governments of Gujarat, Maharashtra and Goa have now relented. This could pave the way for ESA protection in about 19,000 sq km of the Western Ghats.

The continuous mountain chain, with a break at the Palakkad Gap on the Tamil Nadu-Kerala border, harbours one of the world's eight "hottest hotspots" of biological diversity. Its land-form influences the monsoon by acting as a barrier to moisture-bearing winds, resulting in bountiful rainfall along the Western Ghats' coastal side. It's the source of the Godavari, Krishna, Cauvery, Periyar, and several other rivers. The region is much more densely populated compared to several other ecologically sensitive areas — the Himalaya, for instance. This means the argument pitting environmental protection against development has gained traction in the region's six states, even though ecologists have consistently emphasised that ESAs would not harm farm livelihoods. In fact, environmental protection could shield agriculturists against climate vagaries.

The Kerala floods of 2018 and the Wayanad landslide in 2024 underscored the perils of not respecting the frailties of the Western Ghats. That's why Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu, which have about two-thirds of the ESA area proposed by the Kasturirangan Committee, need to be brought on board urgently. The benefits of ecological services provided by the Western Ghats — water security, carbon sequestration, biodiversity conservation and climate regulation — extend beyond the region. Some ecologists, therefore, believe that a system to remunerate the area's people for such services could help reconcile economic aspirations with ecological realities and break the impasse on the Kasturirangan Committee report in the southern states. Such conversations need to inform policymaking.

On Western Ghats, South must break impasse



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The Western Ghats, also known as the Sahyadri Hills, are well known for their rich and unique assemblage of flora and fauna. The range is called Sahyadri in northern Maharashtra and Sahya Parvatham in Kerala.

The northern portion of the narrow coastal plain between the Western Ghats and the Arabian Sea is known as the Konkan Coast.

The central portion is called Kanara and the southern portion is called Malabar region or the Malabar Coast.

The foothill region east of the Ghats in Maharashtra is known as Desh, while the eastern foothills of central Karnataka state is known as Malanadu.

In the south the range is known as the Nilgiri malai in Tamil Nadu.

The Western Ghats is one of the eight hotspots of biological diversity in the world and is spread across six states : Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

Anamudi (2,695 m) is the highest peak in the whole of southern India.

On Western Ghats, South must break impasse

Committees for Western Ghats:

Gadgil Committee (2011): Also known as the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (WGEEP), it recommended that all of the Western Ghats be declared as the Ecological Sensitive Areas (ESA) with only limited development allowed in graded zones.

Kasturirangan Committee (2013): It sought to balance the development and environment protection in contrast to the system proposed by the Gadgil report.

The Kasturirangan committee recommended that instead of the total area of Western Ghats, only 37% of the total area should be brought under ESA and a complete ban on mining, quarrying and sand mining be imposed in ESA.

QUESTION

GS

Hard

Indian Geography

Prelims 2017

Consider the following statements:

1. In India, the Himalayas are spread over five States only.
2. The Western Ghats are spread over five States only.
3. Pulicat Lake is spread over two States only.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

Select an option to attempt

A 1 and 2 only

B 3 only

C 2 and 3 only

D 1 and 3 only

India's rise merits a seat at the UNSC



BIMAL N PATEL AND ANKIT K

India's rise merits a seat at the UNSC

INDIA'S PERMANENT membership of the UN Security Council is no longer a question of aspiration. It has become a test of whether the world can adapt to the current geopolitical flux. Since World War II, the world has fundamentally changed, overseen by an institution that largely has not. India, as the world's largest democracy, represents one-sixth of its total population. Recognising its rightful place will ensure the UNSC's credibility in addressing global challenges.

India ranks among the top three in purchasing power parity, with estimates placing its 2026 GDP PPP above \$20 trillion. It influences global trade flows, technology supply chains, energy markets, and developmental finance. India's armed forces are among the world's largest and it is among the top defence spenders, with its 2026 defence budget reaching a record \$86 billion. India is currently among the few countries with a credible nuclear triad, yet its strategic culture has remained oriented toward deterrence and stability, rather than revising the international order.

Beyond material capabilities, India's normative and functional contribution to international peace and security is noteworthy. Its troop contribution has been one of the largest since 1948 despite suffering one of the highest numbers of fatalities among UN peacekeeping contributors. This reflects India's com-

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mitment to multilateralism and its willingness to support UN mandates at all costs.

On several crucial international agendas, India is one of the major stakeholders, shaping outcomes in energy transitions, green finance, and technological innovation. Cutting across the North-South divide, India demonstrated its leadership in the International Solar Alliance and the recent G20 presidency under the theme "*vasudhaiva kutumbakam*". It is emerging as a hub in technology governance. On maritime security, its role in the Indian Ocean shows strong commitment to freedom of navigation and adherence to the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea and its institutions such as the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea.

Equitable representation is one of the most important challenges the UNSC faces. Despite Asia accounting for 60 per cent of the world's population, only one Asian state holds a permanent seat. UNSC expansion can also address challenges that directly affect Asian countries but often receive inadequate attention, while preventing the pursuit of any single country's narrow agenda.

The G4 initiative, by India, Japan, Brazil and Germany, aims at increasing UNSC membership, with six new permanent seats, including two each for Asia and Africa.

Since permanent membership comes with veto power, restricting it to only five countries has resulted

in structural and functional challenges. In the 1960s, the UNSC expanded the number of non-permanent members to 10 without making any changes to the P5. Thus, the influence of the permanent members increased over time. The growing practice of consensus-based decision-making has given rise to de facto vetoes. Outcomes such as presidential and press statements, or the decisions of sanctions committees, require unanimity, allowing any member, permanent or elected, to block or delay action. As the Council expands, achieving consensus becomes more difficult, thereby increasing opportunities for individual states to exercise this informal veto in pursuit of narrow national interests. Equitable reform requires expanding permanent membership with veto power to ensure fair representation.

A permanent seat for India at the Council would strengthen stability in Asia and beyond. It would closely align the institution with changing geopolitical realities and establish the legitimacy of its decisions, offering the UNSC a chance to revamp itself. The India of today, envisioned as *vishwamitra*, is well positioned to address the evolving challenges of the UNSC.

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India's rise merits a seat at the UNSC

The United Nations Security Council is one of the six principal organs of the UN and is considered the apex of the UN system.

The UNSC is the only UN body with the authority to issue binding resolutions on member states.

It consists of fifteen members, and each member has one vote.

Permanent Members: Five (China, France, Russia, UK, and US) (P5)

Non-permanent members: Ten

Each year, the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) elects five non-permanent members by a two-thirds majority for two years on a regional basis.

A retiring member is not eligible for immediate re-election.

The five permanent members have veto power, opposition from any of these five Countries blocks the resolution regardless of international support.

India is not a permanent member of the UNSC.

In 2021, India was elected as a non-permanent member of the UNSC for the eighth time. Non-permanent members get monthly presidency of UNSC, and as a president, they could decide the matter to discuss in meetings.

Non-permanent members can preside over several committees and working groups of UNSC.

India's rise merits a seat at the UNSC

L.69 Group

It is a pre-reform group of developing countries. The group is seeking an expansion of permanent and non-permanent membership to the UNSC

G4 Group

It comprises four countries: Brazil, India, Germany, and Japan They support each other's bids to become permanent members of the UNSC.

Coffee Club

It is an informal group comprising 40 member states. It has been instrumental in holding back reforms to the UNSC.

Why should India get a permanent membership at UNSC ?

- 1. Adapting to the current geopolitical flux**
- 2. India is today a country with 1/6th of the world's population and is the largest democracy in the world**
- 3. India is a country with credit nuclear triad which leans towards deterrence and stability**
- 4. UN Peacekeeping Forces and their contributions**
- 5. Leader in various domains**

Q. With reference to United Nations Security Council (UNSC), consider the following statements:

1. Its objective is to maintain international peace and security.
2. It is the only organ of UN that has the power to take decisions that the Member States are obligated to implement.
3. Each year the UN General Assembly elects five non-permanent members for UNSC, out of 10 in total, for a one -year term.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

[A] 1 and 2 only

[B] 2 and 3 only

[C] 1 and 3 only

[D] 1, 2 and 3

Clearing the road to timely trauma care in India

Clearing the road to timely trauma care in India

On May 26, 2026, the Supreme Court of India delivered a landmark judgment with implications for public health policy. Hearing a writ petition filed by SaveLIFE Foundation in October 2024, a Bench of Justices J.K. Maheshwari and Atul S. Chandurkar, in *SaveLIFE Foundation & Anr. vs Union of India & Ors.*, held that the right to trauma care is an integral part of the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution. The Court ruled that this right extends from the site of injury to definitive hospital treatment and issued nine binding directions to the Union, States and Union Territories, with implementation timelines ranging from three to six months.

Around 4.67 lakh Indians die every year from injuries such as road crashes, falls, burns, drowning, industrial mishaps, fires and disasters, according to National Crime Records Bureau data. Road crashes alone account for nearly 1.77 lakh deaths. Trauma is the leading cause of death among Indians aged 18-45. The Law Commission (201st Report) has estimated that half of road-crash fatalities could be prevented with timely care, while a 2021 NITI Aayog-AIIMS Emergency and Injury Care Report found that at least 30% of deaths are linked to delays in emergency response. India does not lack policies or guidelines; what it has lacked is a uniform, enforceable trauma-care framework.

What the top court has held

The Bench built on earlier jurisprudence. In *Parmanand Katara vs Union of India* (1989), the Court recognised the duty of doctors to render emergency aid. In *Paschim Banga Khet Mazdoor Samiti vs State of West Bengal* (1996), it read access to emergency care into Article 21. In the present order, Article 21, the Court held, covers the entire chain that connects an injured person to medical care: the bystander, the emergency call, the ambulance, the paramedic, the receiving facility.



Piyush Tewari

The Founder and the CEO of SaveLIFE Foundation, a non-profit committed to saving lives through road safety and trauma care

Judicial oversight may finally realise the constitutional right to trauma care

The framing imposes a positive obligation on the state to build and sustain an integrated trauma response system.

This matters because survival in trauma depends on systems rather than on individual institutions. A well-equipped hospital cannot compensate for a delayed ambulance. An ambulance cannot help if the bystander is afraid to call. A trauma surgeon cannot save a patient who never reaches the hospital in time.

A cooperative federalism approach

Public health, hospitals and ambulance services fall under the State List in the Seventh Schedule, making cooperation between the Union and the States essential for a uniform trauma-care framework. Compliance affidavits and information notes filed by 34 States and Union Territories indicate a willingness to implement Union policies and standardise trauma care. Accepting the Attorney General's submission that the Union should act as an enabler, the Bench called for "sustained and concerted efforts" by both levels of government. The directions do not alter the constitutional division of powers; they provide judicial backing to existing frameworks such as Prime Minister - Road Accident Victims' Hospitalisation and Assured Treatment (PM RAHAT), the National Ambulance Code AIS-125, Emergency Response Support System (ERSS)-112, the emergency medical technician (EMT) curriculum, the Good Samaritan Rules and the Health Ministry's trauma-care guidelines.

The directions fall into five clusters. On communications, all emergency numbers (100, 101, 102, 108, 1033, 1091 and their State variants) must be integrated into helpline 112 within three months, with mass media publicity. On bystander protection, every State must set up physical and digital grievance-redress systems for Good Samaritans, with nodal authorities at the State and district levels. On pre-hospital response, all

registered ambulances, public and private, must comply with the National Ambulance Code, carry GPS integrated in real time with helpline 112, and undergo structured audits of response times and clinical outcomes. States must also adopt the National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions (NCAHP)-notified EMT curriculum. On hospitals, trauma facilities must be graded and designated so their capabilities are transparent. On finance, States have eight weeks to operationalise PM RAHAT, the Centre's cashless treatment scheme for road-crash victims; non-implementation will count as a violation of the Motor Vehicles Act. The Court has additionally directed the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare to notify a national medical rescue protocol and a Trauma Registry data format, with State trauma registries to link up to a coordinated national registry.

A follow-up, the challenges

The order's significance lies as much in its compliance architecture as in its constitutional declaration. Copies will be sent to every Chief Secretary, Action Taken Reports must be filed with the Court Registry, and the Attorney General of India is to monitor implementation. The matter has been listed to be heard again in about four months for further directions.

Implementation will be challenging. State capacity varies widely, ambulance networks remain uneven, and helpline integration has lagged for long. The burden of inaction, however, has shifted. States must now demonstrate progress before the Court. For an injured Indian, the question after a crash or a fall should no longer be which number to call, whether help will arrive, or whether there is a capable hospital nearby. The Court has settled the constitutional question; governments must now ensure that timely and effective trauma care becomes a reality.

Changed Reality: India Must Reduce Its Dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

The Supreme Court of India has recognised **access to trauma care as an integral part of the Right to Life under Article 21** of the Constitution.

In **SaveLIFE Foundation & Anr. vs Union of India & Ors.**, The Court introduced measures aimed at strengthening trauma and emergency care for accident victims nationwide, ensuring timely treatment from the point of injury to advanced hospital care.

Unified Emergency Helpline: The Court directed all States and Union Territories to integrate existing emergency and ambulance helplines, including 100, 101, 102, 108, 1033 and 1091, into the **single national emergency number 112** within three months.

The judgment called for a **uniform and robust trauma-care system across the country**, aimed at reducing preventable deaths resulting from road accidents and other emergencies.

Ambulance Reforms: All registered ambulances are required to comply with the National Ambulance Code and adopt GPS-based tracking systems to improve emergency response efficiency.

PACOM, the deeper meaning behind a dropped prefix

PACOM, the deeper meaning behind a dropped prefix

The decision by the United States military to change the name of its naval command in the region from “US INDOPACOM” to “US PACOM” – United States Indo-Pacific Command to United States Pacific Command – reverting to its original name that was changed in 2018 can be dismissed as superficial, even trivial. Many have already responded with the Shakespearean “What’s in a name?”, even as the U.S. Department of War pointed out that US PACOM’s area of responsibility, from “the waters off the West Coast of the United States to the western border of India” or what had once been described as “Hollywood to Bollywood, from polar bears to penguins”, has never changed. In 2018, U.S. Defence Secretary Jim Mattis said that the name INDOPACOM was a recognition of the “growing significance” of the Indian Ocean, the Indian subcontinent, and India itself, and the U.S. dropped the term “Asia-Pacific” to “Indo-Pacific”.

Current U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth gave the signal, on May 30, that this understanding has now changed, at his speech at the annual Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore – compared to more than 30 references to the “Indo-Pacific” in his speech in 2025, his speech this year contained not a single reference to the Indo-Pacific region or strategy.

Given the centre stage that the U.S.’s Indo-Pacific policy has had in India’s strategic calculus since 2018, it is necessary, therefore, to go beyond the superficial to the subterranean or submarine, in this case. New Delhi must study how broader trends in U.S. policy are attempting to recast both the region and India’s position within it in terms of three broader geographies.

U.S.-China ties and the Quad

The first, is the U.S.’s outreach to China, and concurrently diminishing salience of the Quad (India, Japan Australia, the U.S.), which Beijing has always protested as an “exclusive clique” or derisively as “ocean foam”. In the long term, the U.S. and China cannot shy away from the fierce rivalry between them, but it is clear that in the immediate term, Trump 2.0 has decided to play nice.

U.S. President Donald Trump’s visit to Beijing in May 2026 and Chinese President Xi Jinping’s upcoming visit to the U.S. on September 24, indicate that the two sides do not want their differences to overcome the relationship, and the U.S. is tiptoeing around the Taiwan issue. Mr. Trump’s references to a “G-2”, including during a press availability with Mr. Modi on the sidelines of the S2nd G-7 summit in France (June 15 to 17), are an early warning of a plan to recast the world into “spheres of influence”, where China would be the predominant power in the continent, not as one pole in a multipolar Asia, as India envisions.

As a result, the Quad, rebuilt in Trump 1.0 as a



Suhasini Haidar

The U.S.’s reversion from INDOPACOM to PACOM suggests that its regional shifts run deeper than a simple name change

counter to China in the region, appears to be floundering. The U.S.’s National Defense Strategy released in January 2026 does not mention the Quad even once. In terms of substance, the Quad’s combined agenda has been pared down to four areas of cooperation – maritime security, economic prosperity, critical and emerging minerals technology and disaster responses. Even within these limited objectives, there have been setbacks, such as over Artificial Intelligence cooperation. Despite Quad countries signing on to Pax Silica, and Critical Minerals Initiative Framework with the U.S., the Trump administration ordered Anthropic to end access to its latest models for all non-Americans.

Another question concerns the Quad Summit, which India has unsuccessfully sought to host since January 2024. During U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio’s visit to Delhi in May 2026, he offered no firm commitment that Mr. Trump would visit Delhi this year, amid indications that the Quad may be relegated to a Foreign Ministers’ level grouping. The U.S. Navy’s reported actions involving Iranian ship *IRIS Dena* (March 2006) and recent attacks on three ships in which three Indians were killed underscore maritime security and domain awareness concerns within the Quad framework. In July, when he hosts Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi and travels to Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand, Prime Minister Narendra Modi must discuss alternative maritime coalitions and revive the Australia-India-Japan trilateral.

The U.S.-Iran MoU and West Asia

The second geography of concern is West Asia. The U.S. ceasefire with Iran, after just a few months of a surprisingly badly planned war, is indicative of a general fatigue in Trump 2.0 with U.S. friends and allies in the region. The situation is even more volatile today than it was prior to February 28, especially given the short shrift Israel has received in negotiations with Iran, and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s defiance over the ceasefire for Lebanon.

A closer look at the 14-paragraph “Islamabad MoU” released by Iran reveals several signals for the region. Paragraph four states that the U.S. commits to “remove its forces from the proximity of the Islamic Republic of Iran” within 30 days after the final deal. Paragraph five says that, after the Hormuz Strait is demined, Iran and Oman will define the Strait’s future administration in consultation with Persian Gulf littoral states.

Paragraph 6 stipulates that the U.S., along with regional allies, will provide at least \$300 billion for Iran’s reconstruction. These provisions imply commitments on behalf of the Cooperation Council for the Arab States of the Gulf (GCC) states while giving Iran leverage on key issues – military, connectivity, and economic security. Oman and Qatar are now closer to Iran than

before and have been part of the Pakistan-led mediation process, while countries such as Saudi Arabia are seeking new security arrangements with Türkiye, Pakistan, and Ukraine.

India’s policy towards the region requires a rapid revision in light of the post-war, post-deal power structure. What was once a finely balanced approach now appears tilted towards Israel and the United Arab Emirates. New Delhi must also urgently reconsider its compliance with U.S. sanctions on Iranian oil and the Chabahar port, given Washington’s shifting positions.

The U.S. and South Asia

Finally, India must study the implications of U.S. foreign policy decisions in its neighbourhood. The appointment of Sergio Gor as both U.S. Ambassador to India and Special Envoy for South and Central Asia signals Washington’s growing regional ambitions. New Delhi has pushed back on attempts by the U.S. to become a supra entity in South Asia, as well as its efforts to resolve intra-regional conflicts between India and Pakistan. This ambition was hinted at during Operation Sindoor (May 2025), and repeated by Mr. Trump over the past year, especially as he met the Pakistani leadership many times in this period.

Mr. Gor’s recent travels to Kathmandu, Thimphu, Dhaka and Colombo indicate that the U.S. is keen to broaden its efforts across the region. In the absence of effective pan-regional frameworks such as the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) and the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) – both are constrained by New Delhi’s political tensions with Islamabad and Dhaka – it is clear that the U.S. is entering into competition with China for influence in South Asia.

Beijing has already built several mechanisms for cooperation with South Asia, and both powers side-stepping India. India, as chair of the Indian Ocean Rim Association, and with Mr. Modi due to attend the planned BIMSTEC summit in Bangladesh and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Pakistan next year, has an opportunity to reassert its regional leadership. Given the opportunities, a revival of the SAARC grouping and other pan-regional initiatives must be considered.

Concerns over the U.S.’s moves across India’s geographies may seem contrary to the bonhomie at the Modi-Trump meeting at the G-7 meet in France, and the red carpet for Mr. Rubio’s India visit. Shorn of the rhetoric, however, the trends in U.S. policy are clear, and New Delhi must plan accordingly, acknowledging that the shifts run far deeper than the ripples on the surface caused by a dropped prefix.

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PACOM, the deeper meaning behind a dropped prefix

The United States military renamed its Indo-Pacific Command from “US INDOPACOM” to “US PACOM,” reverting to the pre-2018 designation. The rename signals a deliberate U.S. retreat from the Indo-Pacific strategic framework

G2 (Group of Two)

The G2 concept was first proposed in 2005 by economist C. Fred Bergsten.

The terminology reflects formal recognition of China's great-power status and promotes the idea that the US and China jointly shoulder responsibility for major global issues, such as macroeconomic stability, global warming, etc., effectively dividing the world into two spheres of influence.

QUAD

The **QUAD began as a humanitarian coordination mechanism** after the **2004 Indian Ocean tsunami**. It focuses on regional security, economic cooperation, maritime safety, infrastructure, and supply chain resilience, **while not being a formal military alliance**.

QUAD Countries, officially the QUADrilateral Security Dialogue, include **Australia, India, Japan, and the US**.

The QUAD has no permanent headquarters. There is no central secretariat. It functions as an informal strategic dialogue.

Changed Reality: India Must Reduce Its Dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

The Path Forward for India: Reviving Regional Leadership

Organizations such as SAARC and BIMSTEC remain constrained by political disagreements and limited effectiveness. This institutional vacuum creates opportunities for external powers to shape regional affairs.

India can strengthen its leadership role by:

Revitalizing SAARC.

Strengthening BIMSTEC.

Utilizing its position in the Indian Ocean Rim Association.

Enhancing cooperation through forums such as the SCO.

Changed Reality: India Must Reduce Its Dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

The **South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)** is a regional organisation established on 8th December 1985 in Dhaka, Bangladesh, to promote economic, social, cultural, and technical cooperation among South Asian countries

It comprises **8 member states: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, the Maldives, and Afghanistan**, with its **headquarters in Kathmandu, Nepal**.

BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) is a regional organization comprising 7 member states as **Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Thailand**.

Objective: It aims to foster multifaceted technical and economic cooperation among countries in the Bay of Bengal region

Origin: It was founded in **1997 with the adoption of the Bangkok Declaration**.

Initially comprising 4 members, it was known as BIST-EC (Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka, and Thailand Economic Cooperation). In 1997, Myanmar joined, and the grouping was renamed BIMST-EC.

With the inclusion of Nepal and Bhutan in 2004, the name was further changed to BIMSTEC.

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Changed Reality: India Must Reduce Its Dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) is a permanent regional intergovernmental body, officially founded on 15 June 2001 in Shanghai, China. It was created by Kazakhstan, China, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan, evolving from the earlier framework known as the Shanghai Five.

Headquarters: The **permanent secretariat of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) is located in Beijing, China.**

10 Members: China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, India, Pakistan, Iran, Belarus.

India and Pakistan joined the grouping in 2017 in its first round of expansion.

Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure

The Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is a permanent organ of the SCO that serves to promote cooperation of member states against the three evils of terrorism, separatism and extremism.

It is headquartered in Tashkent.

The head of RATS is elected for a three-year term.

Thank You